THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #011

HASSAN EL MGHARI AND THE WEEKEND DEMOS THAT REACHED MILLIONS OF PEOPLE

A developer who builds AI apps in a weekend, open-sources them and lets them go viral has reached millions of visitors and turned the projects into a career. It is not a standalone company, and that is exactly why it is worth copying.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Hassan El Mghari, Developer and open-source builder; leads developer experience at Together AI
COMPANY	roomGPT, restorePhotos, LlamaCoder and other apps
FOUNDED	2023
HQ	New York City
SECTOR	Consumer and developer AI apps
STAGE	Side projects alongside a full-time role
FUNDING	None reported
MODEL	Free open-source demos; roomGPT sold credit packs

Hello again, and welcome to File #011. Thank you for reading.

A new AI model appears. Within a week, someone has used it to build something that makes people say "oh, that's what it can do". They put it online, open-source the code, and it spreads. A few days later, hundreds of thousands of people have tried it.

If you spend any time around AI products, you have seen this happen. One of the people who does it most reliably is Hassan El Mghari. This file is about how he does it, what it has and hasn't earned him, and why it is a different sort of success from the others in this series. (All figures are in US dollars. Visitor and user counts come from his own site or from other people's reports, and we label them.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Hassan El Mghari, a New York-based developer who builds AI apps in public, and who now leads developer experience at Together AI.
- **What:** a run of free, open-source AI apps. roomGPT redesigns a room from a photo. restorePhotos repairs old pictures. LlamaCoder turns a request into a working app. BlinkShot makes images in real time.
- **Why it matters:** it is the clearest example of the "build a focused demo the week a new model appears" playbook, and of what that playbook produces when the goal is reach and craft, not a company.
- **The number to remember:** 12 million. The number of visitors his own site lists for roomGPT. It is a visitor count, not a customer count, and the difference between them is the story.

THE FOUNDER

Hassan's own site describes him as a developer who builds open-source AI apps and teaches other developers about AI, which is his job. He lives in New York. He says he has worked at "a few startups like Vercel", and also ran a game marketing company for a while. In a 2025 talk he described a path that began with freelance Ruby work in high school.

His job title has changed and is described differently in different places. In April 2025 a Cloudflare programme introduced him as Senior Manager of Developer Relations at Together AI, and a conference page lists him as Director of Developer Experience. His own site currently says he leads developer experience there and manages a team that works on demos, docs and content. We use the description on his own site.

That detail matters for how to read everything else. Together AI sells computing power for running open AI models. Many of Hassan's recent demos run on Together's models. The apps are, among other things, an effective advertisement for his employer, and he is open about that being his job.

THE PLAYBOOK

Pieced together from his talks and interviews, the method is simple.

1. Wait for a new capability. roomGPT began when a technique called ControlNet made AI interior redesign good enough to be useful: it preserves the structure of a room. He prototyped quickly to confirm it worked, then built the app over what he describes as one or two weekends. Starter Story puts it at seven days.

2. Make it explainable in one sentence. He says he keeps demos simple enough to describe in a sentence. The core of roomGPT, he has said, is a single call to the model.

3. Make it feel like a real product. Then he adds the things that turn a demo into something people trust: sign-in, a dashboard, credits.

4. Open-source it. The code goes on GitHub, which gives it a second life with developers. His own site lists 10,000 stars for roomGPT, 6,000 for LlamaCoder and 8,000 for his AI Commits tool.

5. Let others spread it. According to the Starter Story write-up, roomGPT's growth came largely from videos made by users on TikTok and YouTube, one of them reportedly past three million views, plus press coverage. The "GPT" in the name tied it to a wave of existing interest.

THE NUMBERS, AND HOW TO READ THEM

APP	WHAT HIS SITE LISTS	NOTES
roomGPT	12 million visitors, 10,000 GitHub stars	First week, per his LinkedIn: about 515,000 unique visitors and 728,000 rooms generated
restorePhotos	5 million visitors, 4,000 stars	
LlamaCoder	2 million visitors, 6,000 stars	
BlinkShot	1.5 million visitors, 1,000 stars	
Self.so	80,000 visitors, 2,000 stars	LinkedIn profile to website
AI Commits	8,000 stars, 40,000 on npm	A command-line tool

An earlier figure from a developer blog he wrote for says the apps he built in the previous year had a combined 2.5 million users. Conference bios have cited more than three million. The differences are mostly dates and definitions. A visitor is someone who opened a page. A user is someone who did something. A customer is someone who paid. His figures are visitor counts, and we shouldn't read them as more than that.

The money is less clear. roomGPT gave each person three free credits and sold packs at $9 for 30, $19 for 100 and $29 for 200. Starter Story lists its revenue at about $23,000 a month and calls it "estimated from public sources", and the annual figure of about $276,000 is just that number multiplied by twelve. It's one estimate, from November 2024. Hassan hasn't published revenue, and we found nothing recent. His site says nothing about revenue at all.

THE STACK

He's open about the tools. A 2024 talk lists TypeScript, Next.js, a Postgres database hosted by Neon, Prisma, Tailwind, Together AI for the models, Vercel for hosting and analytics and Clerk for sign-in. He says he chooses what lets him prototype fastest. Early versions used Replicate for the models and a mix of Python and Flask behind the scenes. LlamaCoder, which one profile describes as an open-source take on Claude's Artifacts feature, was built on a large open Llama model running on Together's platform.

WHAT HE HAS DONE LATELY

His 2026 work follows the same pattern. A profile lists a tool called Bygga, launched on 27 October, which walks you through assembling flat-pack furniture step by step with an interactive 3D view and voice instructions. In July he released a set of browser games in which open and closed models build small games head to head. We couldn't verify either beyond the profile and his own posts. He also talks about open-sourcing things so that other developers can build on them, and says he supports free access through usage limits and partnerships with providers that sponsor computing and other services.

WHY THIS ISN'T A STARTUP STORY

Most files in this series are about someone building a business. This one is about someone building a reputation, and using it.

That matters because the outcomes are different. He didn't try to turn roomGPT into a venture-funded company. The apps are free to try, the code is public, and the main payoff is an audience and a career. Copycats appear quickly, and open-sourcing invites them. Virality is not the same as durable revenue.

Try this

Pick one capability that just arrived. Write down what a stranger could do with it that they couldn't last month. Build that one thing.

Pass the one-sentence test. If you can't explain the demo in a sentence, it's probably too big for a weekend.

Add sign-in and a dashboard before you launch, so that people treat it as a product and not a toy.

Publish the code if you're after reach. Open source gives you a second audience, and a reason for people to write about you.

Decide what the project is for. Revenue, reputation and a job offer lead to different choices. Hassan's are clearly the last two.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

Virality fades. Interest in a demo falls quickly. A million visitors in a month doesn't mean a million next year.

Clones. An open-source app can be copied by anyone, and AI interior and photo tools are crowded categories. Without a business built around it, there isn't much to protect.

Revenue is mostly unknown. We have one estimate for one app from 2024. We have nothing for the others.

Employer interests. His demos promote the platform his employer sells. That's openly his job, but it means the apps are marketing as much as products.

Dependence on models and hosting. The apps run on other people's models. When prices, terms or capabilities change, the apps change with them.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **Whether the 2026 apps repeat the reach** of roomGPT and restorePhotos, or whether novelty has worn off.
2. **Any revenue disclosure,** which would turn a good story about audience into a story about income.
3. **What roomGPT is doing now.** It was still active and reported as profitable in late 2024. We found nothing since.
4. **The next model.** The method depends on being early to a capability. Which one is next?

A developer with a laptop, an eye for what's newly possible, and the patience to build it properly in a weekend. For the right goal, that's more valuable than it sounds.

That's File #011. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #012 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Hassan El Mghari's own site, talks and posts, Starter Story (revenue figures are its estimate) and press and profile coverage. We haven't spoken to him or verified any figure. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

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- LlamaCoder by Together AI, TestingCatalog. testingcatalog.com
- The builders behind 2026's weirdest viral AI apps, Differ. blog.getdiffer.com